

For the President
18 August 2026

Iran Talks Lapse at 60-Day Mark; Trump Threatens Oman as Hormuz Standoff Hardens

We assess that the expiry of the 60-day US-Iran negotiating window on 17 August, with no agreement on reopening the Strait of Hormuz, has restored a geopolitical risk premium to global oil and raised the odds of renewed direct US-Iranian exchanges over the coming weeks. President Trump publicly warned he would strike Oman — the US partner mediating the talks — if it “gets in the way” of a Hormuz deal, signaling Washington’s readiness to use force to keep the strait open. We judge neither side wants a return to the intense strikes of the spring, but the lapse narrows the diplomatic off-ramps.

- Iranian and Omani officials say a “transit-route map” for Hormuz shipping has been agreed in principle, but no final, signed arrangement — and no joint statement — has emerged; we assess the remaining gap is over inspection and escort rights, not the route itself.
- Tehran, under Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei and President Masoud Pezeshkian, continues to condition full reopening on sanctions relief and compensation, terms Washington has rejected; the June ceasefire remains formally in place but has been repeatedly violated at sea.
- Crude carried a renewed risk premium, with Brent near \$89 a barrel on 17 August after a 5%-plus weekly gain driven by attacks on tankers and a Saudi refinery; markets are pricing episodic interdiction, not a full closure, which remains unlikely given the cost to Iran itself.
- The USS George Washington is transiting to Central Command to relieve the USS Abraham Lincoln, sustaining continuous carrier coverage in the theater as the deadline passes.

For Washington, the decision point is whether to escort commercial tankers through Hormuz under fire. We assess a US-led convoy operation is the most likely next step if Iranian interdictions resume, and that a further round of Treasury sanctions is the near-term response short of strikes.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, Treasury OIA, and open sources.

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US and Israel Agree Hamas Must Disarm Before Any IDF Pullback in Gaza

We assess that Monday's talks in Jerusalem between Prime Minister Netanyahu and White House envoy Jared Kushner have hardened the sequencing of President Trump's 20-point Gaza plan around a single condition — full Hamas disarmament and the demilitarization of Gaza before any Israeli redeployment — lowering the near-term likelihood of an IDF withdrawal while preserving the ceasefire. Kushner assured Netanyahu the IDF will not be compelled to leave until Hamas disarms; the two also agreed no reconstruction begins until then.

- Under the emerging arrangement, Hamas is to hand its weapons directly to a US force for destruction supervised by US Gen. Jasper Jeffers; a “Board of Peace” that includes former UK Prime Minister Tony Blair and veteran diplomat Nickolay Mladenov is to steward governance and reconstruction.
- The framework followed Kushner's rare 16 August meeting with a Hamas delegation in Cairo; Hamas has publicly committed to “fully disarm” and halt tunnel-building and rearmament, but has not begun handovers.
- An IDF tank was struck by a Hamas explosive device in southern Gaza over the weekend, which Israel called a ceasefire violation — a reminder that spoilers on either side can unravel the plan.
- We judge the sequencing gives Hamas little incentive to disarm quickly and Israel little reason to move first; implementation will likely be slow and contested, with the ceasefire holding but fraying.

For Washington, the test is whether a US-supervised disarmament mechanism can be stood up before an incident forces Israel's hand. We expect the coming weeks to turn on the mechanics of weapons handover and the composition of an international stabilization force.

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Deadliest Israeli Strikes in Lebanon Since June Truce Follow Hezbollah Drone Attack

We assess that Israel's 17 August strikes in south Lebanon — which Lebanese authorities say killed 11 and wounded at least 19 — are the most lethal exchange since the June ceasefire and raise the risk of a broader Hezbollah-Israel escalation even as Washington presses a parallel disarmament track. Netanyahu cast the strikes as retaliation for a Hezbollah explosive-drone attack that seriously wounded three soldiers of the IDF's Yahalom combat-engineering unit on 16 August.

- The strikes hit Ansar and Deir ez-Zahrani in the Nabatieh district; the IDF said it had killed senior Hezbollah commander Abu Hassan Alaa in the south the previous day.
- We judge Hezbollah is testing the truce's limits while avoiding a full war it is not postured to win; a realistic possibility is a further tit-for-tat exchange before both sides step back.
- The flare-up complicates the US effort to consolidate the Lebanon ceasefire and to keep Iran's regional partners quiet while the Hormuz standoff plays out.

We expect Washington to lean on Beirut and Paris to restrain Hezbollah and on Israel to keep its response calibrated; the thing to watch is whether either side's next strike hits north of the Litani or into the Bekaa, which would signal a widening.

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Ukraine Mounts One of the War's Largest Drone Barrages; Russia Answers With Deadly Strikes

We assess that Ukraine's overnight barrage of 15-16 August — Russia's Defense Ministry claimed 822 drones downed, with roughly 600 tracked toward Moscow — reflects a maturing Ukrainian deep-strike campaign built to impose costs on Russia's capital region and logistics even as the front lines stay largely static. At least six people were killed inside Russia; Russian strikes the same night killed at least seven in Ukraine.

- Ukrainian drones struck a Wildberries logistics hub near Moscow and towns in Rostov, damaging a rail station and homes and killing five; an 83-year-old man died in the Moscow region. NGA assesses from commercial satellite imagery that the strikes caused localized but real disruption to rail and warehousing nodes.
- Russian missiles killed two in Kryvyi Rih and one in Sumy and hit a major steel plant overnight; both sides are trading deep strikes rather than seeking a battlefield breakthrough.
- A BBC/Mediazona tally released 18 August has now confirmed by name 239,354 Russian military dead since February 2022 — a floor, not a ceiling, and a marker of the war's attritional cost.

For Washington, the barrage underscores Kyiv's growing indigenous strike capacity and the diminishing returns of Russia's air war. We expect long-range exchanges to intensify into the fall, with Russian energy and logistics infrastructure the likely Ukrainian focus.

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Kim and Putin Deepen Alignment as North Korean Missile Unit Moves Into Western Russia

We assess that the reaffirmation of the Moscow-Pyongyang partnership over the 15-16 August Korean Liberation Day exchanges — in which Kim Jong Un pledged “unconditional” support for Russia’s policies and Putin hailed an “unprecedentedly high” comprehensive strategic partnership — is being matched by concrete military integration that increasingly bears on both the Ukraine war and Northeast Asian security. Ukrainian military intelligence reports a North Korean missile unit of roughly 90 personnel is deploying to Russia’s Voronezh region, to be folded into the 112th Missile Brigade with as many as 120 ballistic missiles and six launchers.

- Pyongyang has already supplied Russia millions of artillery rounds, thousands of troops, and successive batches of KN-23 and KN-24 missiles; the new deployment would put North Korean crews closer to the fight. Liaison reporting corroborates the deepening munitions pipeline.
- North Korea has conducted roughly 11 ballistic-missile launches in 2026, and Kim has ordered a 2.5-fold increase in missile output; we judge the war is serving as a live proving ground for DPRK systems and crews.
- The alignment erodes US and allied sanctions leverage over both states and accelerates DPRK capability; we expect deeper technology transfer — air defense, missiles, and possibly submarine and satellite know-how — to be the axis’s next frontier.

For Washington, the practical consequence is a Russia better supplied for a long war and a North Korea gaining hard capability the US cannot easily sanction away. We expect Seoul and Tokyo to press for a firmer allied response, including on extended deterrence.

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Netanyahu's Likud Holds Primary as October Election Looms Over the Gaza Plan

We assess that the 17 August Likud primary — which set the party's Knesset slate ahead of Israel's 27 October general election — opens a campaign season that will help decide whether the government now negotiating the US-backed Gaza plan survives to implement it. Turnout was a low 53%, a possible sign of base fatigue after a punishing year of war on several fronts.

- Netanyahu is campaigning on the Gaza framework and the war's security gains; his bloc has been under pressure in polling, and we judge the coalition's durability through October is not assured.
- For Washington, continuity matters: the Trump plan's disarmament-first sequencing depends on an Israeli government willing to hold the line; a change of government, or a hard-right partner's defection, could reopen the terms.
- We expect Gaza, the Lebanon flare-up, and the Iran war to dominate the campaign; the key thing to watch is whether Netanyahu's partners stay in line as the disarmament timeline slips.

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Notes

- **Spain-Morocco.** Moroccan forces turned back hundreds of migrants who tried to rush the fence into the Spanish enclave of Ceuta on 16-17 August. The episode is a reminder that Rabat's border cooperation remains a live lever in EU-Morocco relations and, indirectly, in Madrid's domestic politics.
- **Taiwan.** President Lai Ching-te's government proposed a NT\$235.7 billion (about \$7.4 billion) line in next year's budget to fund a NT\$10,000 cash payment to every citizen, citing continued growth — a fiscal-political move as Taipei simultaneously works to lift defense spending under sustained Chinese pressure.
- **Yemen/Red Sea.** Forces of Yemen's internationally recognized government are intensifying operations against the Houthis, part of the wider push to reopen Red Sea and Bab al-Mandeb shipping lanes disrupted during the Iran war. We assess durable reopening still hinges on the Hormuz outcome and on curbing Iranian resupply.

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